

- AMD Athlon II X2 240, 2.8GHz
- GIGABYTE GA-MA785GT-UD3H motherboard (AMD 785G chipset)
- Transcend JetRAM DDR3-1333 2GBx1
- Nvidia GeForce 9400GT 1GB (more on this, later)
- Western Digital Caviar 7200RPM 1TB SATA hard drive
- Lite-On iHFS208 Blu-ray Reader/DVD writer

This entire thing should cost you around Rs 21,000. The Blu-ray drive costs Rs 8,200, but is a pain to procure in India. If you can't find it, Sony has one that costs Rs 16,000 (just double Lite-On's price). I went with Nvidia's 9400GT (the 1GB model) because at this moment, Linux support for AMD/ATI's Avivo HD is a bit unpredictable, whereas Nvidia's VDPAU works like a charm. On the other hand, if you plan to dual boot Windows and play Crysis at 1080p, you'll need to put in a 1GB ATI Radeon HD4870, which is a heat factory and costs Rs 14,000.

The next part of the shopping list includes the materials for our TV and remote controls: Hauppauge WinTV-HVR-1800 D/A HD TV tuner card (it's a bit on the higher end).

It's difficult to recommend a specific remote to control your computer with, as remote control availability matters. If all else fails, you can get an IR receiver and use your Tata Sky remote rather creatively, training LIRC manually to recognise your remote. Why do you need a remote? When you are using your media centre app, you wouldn't exactly like using a mouse and a keyboard from your couch...

The TV tuner is an analogue/digital HDTV tuner, which can receive signals from normal coaxial cable connections (analogue) or your set-top box as well (digital). Additionally, it has an FM tuner. Enjoy...

You'll need a keyboard and mouse as well—try laying your hands on the Microsoft Wireless Desktop Combo 800, because at Rs 1400, a wireless mouse and keyboard with a 10 metre range is a steal.

As for a case, naturally, since it's going to lie in front of your living room TV, you'll want something pretty; preferably lying down, rather than a tower case. However, please don't go overboard, because the Nvidia card needs a bit of cooling, as does AMD's processors. You may want a third-party SMPS as well—a Corsair VX450 will cost you around Rs 4,100. This ensures better stability.

Pepping the rig

It's a little difficult to find a Nvidia GeForce 9400GT with HDMI output. Luckily, the DVI connector on the card is HDCP compliant and thus a DVI-to-HDMI cable can be used to connect your TV to the card. The digital signal used in DVI and HDMI is the same, so there is no impact on the quality. However, you won't get any sound on the TV, so you'll need to mute it.

The motherboard has all the audio you can ask for: A 2-channel front panel and a 7.1-channel rear panel. Use



Figure 1: XBMC Home Screen

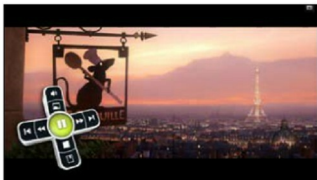


Figure 2: Playing an HD movie in XBMC

them according to your convenience.

The two PCIe x16 slots are meant for CrossFireX, but single Nvidia cards do not have any problem on an AMD chipset. You won't be able to SLI, however. On the upside, you have a free PCIe x16 slot that can be used by all PCIe cards.

You'll need Internet connectivity on this machine. But due to the lack of a normal UI (GNOME, KDE, etc) you won't be able to connect manually through PPPoE, dial-up or even through a browser. Your connection needs to be 'always-on'.

A little theory

Okay, here goes. Have you heard of 10-foot interfaces? These are user interfaces that have been designed with large elements that can be comfortably used by people sitting up to 10 feet away from the screen. 10-foot interfaces are almost exclusively used by media centre apps.

And what are media centre apps? Technically, they provide a homogeneous 10-foot interface that represents a uniform way to access all the digital media in the computer, either in hard disks or any removable media. One of the best media centre apps in Linux is the XBox Media Center, or XBMC. A review has been published in *LFY* recently, and this article puts it to good use.

Technically, your plasma (or LCD) screen is just a monitor as far as your PC is concerned. To be able to run XBMC, your TV must support either 720p, 1080p or any standard VGA resolution. Support for interlaced